

IS YOUR CHARACTER A TYPE OR A HISTORY?

A nine-question self-assessment, and the one question AI can never answer for you.

AI companies have risked billion-dollar lawsuits for access to modern fiction as training data. They desperately need more of it. And research shows their models still can't generate it well. Researchers call this the AI-Fiction Paradox, and it isn't a data problem. It's structural.

AI knows types. It knows how husbands in general respond to financial pressure, how detectives in general respond to a first suspect, how mothers in general respond to a child leaving. It produces those responses fluently. What it cannot produce is a character who is not a type — a character who is a history.

This assessment isn't about your writing skill. It's about whether the character you're working on right now could have been generated by a prompt, or whether they could only have come from you. Answer honestly, based on your protagonist or whoever carries the most scenes.

HOW TO TAKE THIS

Nine questions. For each one, check whichever option is closer to true for your character — not the answer that sounds better, the one that's actually accurate right now. There's no option C. If you're torn, that hesitation is itself useful information — note it and move on.

THE ASSESSMENT

1. Think of your character's defining reaction to pressure.

- ☐ **A** It's the reaction most people in their role, job, or archetype would have.
- ☐ **B** It's a reaction that makes sense only once you know something specific about their past.

2. Could you swap your character into another writer's story in the same genre?

- ☐ **A** Yes — they'd function fine as someone else's detective, mother, or soldier.
- ☐ **B** No — the specific way they carry the role would read as wrong for anyone else's story.

3. How would you describe what's driving your character in one sentence?

- ☐ **A** A label: ambitious, guarded, loyal, broken.
- ☐ **B** An incident: something that happened, to them specifically, that still operates in the present.

4. Is there a small, specific detail about them that never appears on the page but that you privately know?

- ☐ **A** Not really — what's on the page is what there is.
- ☐ **B** Yes — a private fact that quietly shapes how you write every scene they're in.

5. If you asked an AI tool to write a scene with this character from a one-paragraph description, what would happen?

- ☐ **A** It would probably get close — the character is describable in a paragraph.
- ☐ **B** It would produce something recognizably generic — no paragraph could carry what makes them specific.

6. Think about the detail that changes how a reader sees this character.

- ☐ **A** It's stated clearly, early, so the reader knows what to expect.
- ☐ **B** It looked like nothing when it first appeared and only matters in retrospect.

7. Put your character in a scene you've never written — a situation from outside your manuscript entirely.

- ☐ **A** You'd need to decide how they'd act by reasoning from their role or trait.
- ☐ **B** You already know exactly how they'd act, and you know precisely why.

8. Where does your character's core behavior come from?

- ☐ **A** From what the plot or genre requires of someone in their position.
- ☐ **B** From a specific person, memory, or moment — real or invented — that belongs only to them.

9. When two characters in your manuscript face the same kind of pressure, how do their responses compare?

- ☐ **A** Structurally similar — competent, but interchangeable in shape.
- ☐ **B** Different in ways that trace back to different histories, not just different traits.

WHAT YOUR ANSWERS MEAN

Count your A's and B's.

MOSTLY A'S — YOU'VE WRITTEN A TYPE

Competent, functional, and recognizable — the character does everything the story needs. But everything you described could plausibly be generated from a prompt, because it's built from role and trait rather than history. This isn't a failure of skill. It's the default output of writing forward from what a character needs to do, instead of backward from what specifically happened to them.

MOSTLY B'S — YOU'VE WRITTEN A HISTORY

Your character's behavior is traceable to something specific, private, and irreplaceable — the kind of logic no model weighting statistical probability could reach, because it was never common enough to learn. Keep protecting that specificity as you revise; it's the least replaceable thing in your manuscript.

A MIX OF BOTH — MOST WRITERS LAND HERE

Some characters in a manuscript are fully excavated; others are still running on role and trait, especially secondary characters introduced to serve plot. Note which questions you answered A. Those are the specific places where a type is standing in for a history.

WHY THIS IS WORTH TAKING SERIOUSLY

Independent research teams have measured AI-generated fiction against human-written fiction, and the findings keep landing in the same place. AI-generated stories show a consistent bias toward the same recognizable plot variants, echoing each other even when prompted differently. Human-written plots are rarely echoed at all, even in pieces.

The reason is structural, not a training gap. Fiction violates a core assumption built into how language models work — the assumption that what's statistically prominent is what's important. In fiction, the opposite is often true. The detail that changes everything is frequently the one that looked like nothing when it arrived. A model calculates the most probable next word. The line a specific character needs is, by definition, the least probable one — the one that could only come from this person, carrying this history, in this exact moment.

That line has never been written anywhere. It lives only in your imagination. It cannot be generated. It has to be surfaced — which is a different problem, and a different tool, than the one most writers reach for when a character feels flat.

IF YOU SCORED MOSTLY A'S

That's not a sign your character is badly written. It's a sign the history hasn't been excavated yet — the specific logic that would make this character irreducibly theirs still exists only as a felt sense, not yet as something on the page. No amount of generated description reaches it, because generation moves in the wrong direction: outward, from a tool toward the page. The history surfaces inward, from a question toward the writer who already carries it.

Write Living Characters: A Fiction Writer's Masterclass teaches the Stratum Socratic Writing Method — using AI as a coach instead of a generator, to excavate the specific history your character already has, one question at a time.